

Transcending Proportionality: Frank Lloyd Wright's Organic Vision through Representation

Architecture, as defined by the *Oxford English Dictionary*, is "the art or science of building or constructing edifices of any kind for human use," while nature is described as "the phenomena of the physical world collectively, especially plants, animals, and other features and products of the earth itself, as opposed to humans and human creations." These definitions suggest a divide between human creations and the natural world. In Frank Lloyd Wright's work, however, this divide is not only bridged but transcended through his organic approach to architecture and representation. Wright's designs, especially *Fallingwater* (1939), use proportionality not to impose order but to integrate architecture into its surroundings. In contrast, Vitruvius, in *Book III: Chapter II of Ten Books on Architecture*, uses natural human proportions to establish harmony but still separates architecture from nature. This essay argues that through his use of representation and proportionality, Wright transcends Vitruvius' classical ideals, fostering a dynamic relationship between architecture and nature.

In *Book III: Chapter II of Ten Books on Architecture*, Vitruvius argues that architectural design should reflect natural laws of symmetry and proportion, drawing direct parallels between the human body and architecture. Vitruvius writes, "in the human body, symmetry is found between forearm, foot, palm, finger, and all the other parts," and this proportionality should guide architectural designs.¹ By using the human body as a model, Vitruvius believed that architecture could achieve a balance of beauty and functionality. However, his use of proportionality seeks to impose human logic onto nature, creating a clear distinction between the built environment and natural phenomena. Vitruvian structures such as temples express this carefully controlled symmetry and balance, distancing themselves from the organic, uncontrolled aspects of the natural world.² This perspective contrasts with Frank Lloyd Wright's approach, where proportionality is not used to impose order but to integrate architecture with its surroundings.

Frank Lloyd Wright's philosophy of organic architecture reimagines how buildings should relate to nature. Instead of using proportion to impose human order on nature, Wright employs it as a tool to achieve harmony and integration. His design for *Fallingwater* (1939) exemplifies this approach. As architectural historian Neil Levine notes, Wright's use of proportionality is evident in how the cantilevered terraces mirror the natural stratification of the rock formations beneath the house, blending the structure into the landscape.³ In contrast to Vitruvius' geometric ideals, Wright's representation of *Fallingwater* shows the building emerging from the landscape, a visual integration that reinforces his belief that architecture should work in harmony with nature. In his 1935 perspective drawing of the

house, Wright highlights the organic relationship between the house and its surroundings. The horizontal planes of the building mimic the natural rock layers, creating visual continuity and emphasizing the integration of architecture and landscape.⁴

Wright's use of natural materials, such as stone quarried from the site, further underscores this philosophy. These materials are rendered realistically in the drawing, their rawness a testament to Wright's desire to keep architecture grounded in its environment.⁵ This is a marked departure from Vitruvian proportionality, where human form and control dominate the natural world, creating structures that stand apart from it.

Wright's 1935 perspective drawing of *Fallingwater* is not merely a technical illustration but a representation of his organic philosophy. One of the most significant aspects of the drawing is the use of layered horizontal planes that echo the natural stratification of the rocks beneath the house. This visual technique connects the building to the landscape, emphasizing the integration of the structure with the earth rather than separation from it. By repeating horizontal lines, Wright reinforces the idea that architecture should mirror the natural environment, not impose upon it.⁶

David Larkin, in *Frank Lloyd Wright: The Masterworks*, highlights how Wright's choice of earth tones in the drawing further enhances the building's connection to nature. The browns, greens, and grays of the house are drawn from the natural palette of the surrounding forest and rocks, creating a seamless visual blend between the structure and its setting.⁷ This use of color contrasts with the Vitruvian ideal of architectural proportionality, which prioritizes order and distinction. Instead, Wright's color choices serve to diminish the separation between the human-made and the natural, highlighting his belief that architecture should harmonize with its environment.

Historian Franklin Toker also underscores the significance of the waterfall beneath *Fallingwater*. In his analysis, Toker observes that the waterfall is not portrayed as a static backdrop but as a dynamic, flowing element that interacts with the house. The water's movement reflects Wright's philosophy of organic architecture, where natural forces shape and influence the design of the building. The fluidity of the water contrasts with the more rigid lines of the house, yet the two coexist in balance, symbolizing the harmony between human design and the natural world.⁸

Additionally, Wright's use of large expanses of glass in the drawing speaks to his desire to create transparency and openness in his designs. Neil Levine points out that the glass windows allow the interior of the house to blend with the outside, offering views of the surrounding landscape and blurring the boundary between inside and outside. By incorporating transparency into the structure, Wright ensures that the building is always

connected to nature.⁹ This design choice contrasts with Vitruvian buildings, which were often enclosed and separated from their environment. Wright's transparent design invites nature in, reflecting his belief that architecture should foster interaction with the environment.

Wright's 1935 perspective drawing of *Fallingwater* goes beyond mere architectural rendering to embody his broader organic philosophy. Each visual element—the layered planes, earth tones, dynamic water, and transparency—emphasizes the integration of the building with its environment. While Vitruvius used proportionality to impose human ideals on nature, Wright's representation illustrates a vision of architecture that is in harmony with nature.

Wright's use of drawing as a tool for architectural representation is essential to his organic philosophy. His sketches are more than just technical drawings; they are reflections of his desire to connect architecture with nature. In the case of *Fallingwater*, Wright's early representations of the house emphasize its integration with the landscape, showing how the building becomes an extension of its surroundings.¹⁰ The horizontal lines of the terraces, depicted in his perspective drawings, mimic the natural flow of the rock strata, and the house appears to float above the waterfall, blending seamlessly into the landscape.¹¹

Through these representations, Wright transcends the limitations of classical architectural proportionality. While Vitruvius used proportionality to create idealized, symmetrical buildings based on the human body, Wright used it to explore the potential for architecture to interact dynamically with its environment. His organic approach challenges Vitruvius' ideal of controlling nature, offering a vision of architecture that is deeply connected to the natural world.

Vitruvius' philosophy serves as a counterpoint to Wright's organic architecture, particularly in the way both architects use proportionality. Vitruvius views the human body as the ideal model for architectural design, and buildings should reflect the symmetry and balance found in nature, particularly in human proportions. However, this approach ultimately separates architecture from nature, using geometric precision to impose human logic on the natural world. Vitruvius' temples, for example, are designed to stand apart from their surroundings, with their proportional harmony representing a controlled, idealized beauty that is distinct from the organic forms of the natural landscape.¹² In contrast, Wright uses proportionality to integrate buildings with nature rather than control it. His designs are guided by the natural forms and materials of the site, creating a dynamic relationship between architecture and the environment. By using proportionality to foster harmony rather than imposing order, Wright redefines the role of architecture in relation to the

natural world. His work challenges traditional boundaries between the built and natural environments, offering a new vision of architecture that exists in harmony with its surroundings.¹³

Frank Lloyd Wright's work represents a radical departure from classical architectural ideals, particularly in his use of proportionality to transcend the divide between architecture and nature. While Vitruvius saw proportionality as a means to impose human order on the natural world, Wright used it to create harmony between architecture and its environment. *Fallingwater* exemplifies this approach, with its seamless integration into the landscape and its use of natural materials and forms. Through his use of representation and proportionality, Wright redefines the relationship between architecture and nature, showing that buildings can exist in harmony with the natural world rather than standing apart from it.

Footnotes:

¹ Vitruvius, *Ten Books on Architecture*, trans. Ingrid D. Rowland (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1999), 74.

² Vitruvius, *Ten Books on Architecture*, 75.

³ Neil Levine, *The Architecture of Frank Lloyd Wright* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1996), 102.

⁴ Franklin Toker, *Fallingwater Rising* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 2003), 55.

⁵ Levine, *The Architecture of Frank Lloyd Wright*, 105.

⁶ David Larkin, *Frank Lloyd Wright: The Masterworks* (New York: Rizzoli, 1993), Here's the continuation and conclusion of the paper:

⁶ David Larkin, *Frank Lloyd Wright: The Masterworks* (New York: Rizzoli, 1993), 112.

⁷ Larkin, *Frank Lloyd Wright: The Masterworks*, 112.

⁸ Toker, *Fallingwater Rising*, 56.

⁹ Neil Levine, *The Architecture of Frank Lloyd Wright* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1996), 108.

¹⁰ Frank Lloyd Wright, *In the Cause of Architecture* (New York: Horizon Press, 1953), 86.

¹¹ David Larkin, *Frank Lloyd Wright: The Masterworks* (New York: Rizzoli, 1993), 114.

¹² Vitruvius, *Ten Books on Architecture*, 77.

¹³ Kenneth Frampton, *Modern Architecture: A Critical History* (New York: Thames & Hudson, 1992), 215.

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